



hieroglyphs  
are picture  
symbols

hieratic script reads  
from right to left

papyrus, made  
by pressing  
together layers  
of strips of reed

illustration shows a  
priest making an offering  
to the god Osiris

### Egyptian hieroglyphic and hieratic script

This ancient Egyptian papyrus manuscript shows two forms of Egyptian writing: hieratic script (left) and hieroglyphic script (right) above the two figures. Hieroglyphic is an elaborate script in which signs take a highly pictorial form, while hieratic is a simplified version of hieroglyphic for ease of speed and writing.

### Prehistory

#### Pictograms

Pictures painted on walls of caves up to 25,000 years ago are considered a precursor to writing, recording information that could then be understood by others.



Cave images by Anasazi Indians

### c. 3200 BCE

#### Egyptian hieroglyphs

Egyptian writing develops 100 years after cuneiform. This script begins as a form of picture writing, and includes signs for words and also sounds. It remains in use until the 4th century CE.

### 8th century BCE

#### The Greek alphabet

The first alphabets, using only consonants, develop in the Levant by c. 1150 BCE. They include the Phoenician alphabet, which spreads to the Greeks through trade, who add vowels.



Greek wax tablet

### 100

#### The Roman alphabet

The Romans adapt the Greek script to write Latin. Through the Roman Empire, this alphabet spreads across Europe and is used for personal as well as official correspondence.

### 3300 BCE

#### Cuneiform

The first true written script is developed by the Sumerians of Mesopotamia. Writing with a reed stylus creates a wedge-shaped impression on tablets of wet clay, which then dry hard.



Mesopotamian tablet

### c. 1900 BCE

#### Chinese writing

The first surviving Chinese writing appears on oracle bones, used in divination. This ancient script is still in use today. Chinese script involves 50,000 characters that stand for words.



Chinese paper scroll

### c. 6th century BCE

#### Parchment

Made from dried and processed animal skins, parchment becomes a popular medium for writing around the 6th century BCE, taking over from papyrus, a paper made from reeds.



Chinese parchment scroll